

This house.



1
ONCE

Every cleaning schedule you have ever downloaded was written for a different house

Somebody else’s weekly list has a conservatory, a utility room and no cat. Yours has whatever it has. Write the rooms down first, with the floor in each one — because the floor decides the method, and half of what goes wrong is a wet mop on wood or a bleach spray on stone.

THE ROOMS, AND WHAT IS UNDERFOOT

Floors decide

ROOM	FLOOR	WHAT MAKES IT HARD

WHO LIVES HERE

Adults Children

Pets Anyone home in the day

Asthma, allergies or a baby — changes the products

WHAT “CLEAN ENOUGH” MEANS HERE

Agree it, or it is never met

This is the most useful line on the page and the one nobody writes. Two people can keep the same house and be measured against two different standards, neither of them said out loud. Say it out loud.

BINS AND RECYCLING

WHICH	DAY	WHOSE JOB

WHERE THE CLEANING THINGS LIVE

WHAT WE PAY SOMEBODY ELSE TO DO

And what it costs

WHAT IS BROKEN AND KEEPS BEING WORKED AROUND

The ten minutes.



2
DAILY

A house is not kept by deep cleans. It is kept by ten minutes, most evenings.

Not every evening — **most**. The difference between a house that feels fine and one that does not is almost never the Saturday; it is whether the kitchen was cleared before bed. Pick five things, time them once, and stop there when the time is up. The timer is the point: it turns an open-ended, resentful job into a short one with an end.

OUR FIVE Write the minutes in, once you have timed it

#	THE JOB	MINS
1		
2		
3		
4		
5		

TEN MINUTES, REALLY

STARTED AT, MOST NIGHTS A time beats good intentions

We start at

WHO DOES THE RESET

WHEN THE HOUSE IS FULLER Guests, half-term, after a party

IF THERE IS ONLY TIME FOR ONE OF THE FIVE Which one, and ...

THE WEEK One column per job

DAY	1	2	3	4	5	NOTE
Mon	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
Tue	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
Wed	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
Thu	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
Fri	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
Sat	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
Sun	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	

THE MORNING VERSION, IF EVENINGS NEVER WORK

WHAT WE LET GO Deliberately, not guiltily

Missing three days does not restart anything and does not mean it failed. The grid is there so you can see that you did it eleven times this month, which is eleven more than the schedule you gave up on in February.

The circuit.



3
WEEKLY

ROOM BY ROOM — AND A NAME AND A NUMBER AGAINST EVERY LINE

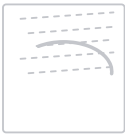
ROOM	THE JOB	WHOSE	MINS	DONE
				☐
				☐
				☐
				☐
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ADD THE MINUTES UP — and that is what you are actually asking of a Saturday

The total at the bottom is the whole point of this page

Nearly every cleaning schedule fails at the same place: it is a list of jobs with no idea how long they take, so it is agreed to cheerfully and abandoned by eleven o'clock. Time each job once, honestly, and add them up. If the number comes to four hours, you have not got a schedule — you have got a wish, and something on this page has to move to page 5, be done less often, or be done by somebody else.

Who does what.



4

AGREE IT

Half the work in a house has no name and nobody thanks you for it

The cleaning is the visible part. The rest is noticing, remembering, reordering, booking and deciding — and in most houses it is all done by one person who did not volunteer. It cannot be shared out until it is written down, so it is written down here with a name beside it like any other job.

THE JOBS NOBODY COUNTS

Put a name against each

THE JOB	WHOSE
Noticing that something has run out, before it runs out	
Actually buying it	
Knowing where things live, so they can be put back	
Booking the boiler, the chimney, the drain, the repair	
Keeping the bins and the recycling in the right week	
Holding the whole list in their head, which is a job in itself	

THE VISIBLE ONES, THEN

The circuit on page 3

THE JOB	WHOSE

WHAT EACH OF US WOULD RATHER DO

It is not all equally hated

WHO	HAPPY TO	WOULD RATHER NOT

CHILDREN, AND WHAT IS ACTUALLY THEIRS

By age, and meant

REVIEWED EVERY SO OFTEN

Nothing here is a life sentence

Last talked about Next

WHAT WE CHANGED, AND WHETHER IT HELD

Monthly, twice a year, once ever.



5
RARELY

ONCE A MONTH Date it when it is done

THE JOB	DONE
☐ Skirting boards, door frames, handles and switches	
☐ Inside the microwave, and the oven door glass	
☐ Descale the kettle and the shower head	
☐ A hot empty cycle and the filter on the washing machine	
☐ Test the smoke alarms	
☐ Under the beds, and behind the sofa	

OURS, AS WELL

Three of these are about fire, not tidiness

Test the smoke alarms monthly and change the batteries yearly. Empty the tumble dryer's lint filter **every single load**, and clean the extractor filter over the hob — both are grease and fluff sitting next to heat. And never leave cloths that have been used with oil screwed up in a warm pile.

TWICE A YEAR Spring, and before the clocks change

THE JOB	DONE
☐ Windows, both sides	
☐ Curtains, blinds and the tops of doors	
☐ The oven, properly	
☐ Defrost the freezer, and eat what is in it first	
☐ Mattresses turned, pillows washed	
☐ Gutters, drains and the outside tap before the frost	

ONCE A DECADE, OR WHEN WE MOVE

IT IS FINE TO SKIP Written down so it stops nagging

Nobody washes their curtains every month, and a list that says they should is a list that gets thrown away in week three. Put the job on the honest shelf instead: twice a year, once a decade, or never — and then stop carrying it around.

What not to mix.



6
PIN UP

NEVER, IN ANY QUANTITY		This is the page to photograph
Bleach + ammonia	Glass and some multi-surface sprays contain ammonia. Together they give off chloramine. Never in the same sink, bowl or cloth.	
Bleach + anything acidic	Vinegar, lemon, limescale removers, some toilet cleaners. Releases chlorine gas.	
Bleach + surgical spirit	Or any rubbing alcohol. Do not.	
Two different drain unblockers	Never one after the other, and never add anything to a pipe that already has one sitting in it.	
Acid on natural stone	Vinegar and limescale remover etch marble, limestone and travertine permanently. Use something made for stone.	
Anything, in a closed bathroom	Open the window or the door first. Gloves on. Never decant into an unlabelled bottle.	

If something is mixed by accident: leave the room, open the windows from outside if you can, and do not go back in to clear it up. If anybody is coughing or short of breath, get them into fresh air and ring for advice — this kit is not medical advice and does not pretend to be.

Minutes, not adjectives.

Most houses need four things, not a cupboard full

Something general for surfaces, something for grease, something for limescale, and good cloths. Everything else is a solved problem being sold twice. Fewer bottles also means fewer chances of two of them meeting.

WHAT WE ACTUALLY USE		And where it is kept
FOR	WHAT	LEFT
		☐
		☐
		☐
		☐
		☐
		☐
		☐

CLOTHS Colour per room stops the worst of it

TRIED AND NOT BUYING AGAIN

When something spills.



7
PIN UP

THE STANDARD METHOD, AND WHAT WORKED HERE

WHAT, AND WHAT TO DO

WHAT WORKED FOR US

Blood, egg, milk, sweat

Cold water only — heat sets protein. Then an enzyme detergent. Never hot.

Red wine

Blot hard, do not rub. Dilute with cold water, blot again, then a stain remover. Salt is folklore; blotting is the work.

Grease and oil

Absorb first with bicarb or cornflour, brush off, then washing-up liquid on what is left.

Ballpoint ink

Cloth underneath, dab with surgical spirit from the back, small area at a time, changing the cloth as it lifts.

Tea and coffee

Cold water straight away, then detergent. On washables, a vinegar rinse helps — not on wool.

Candle wax

Harden it with ice, scrape off the ridge, then brown paper and a warm iron to draw the rest out.

A pet accident

Blot, then an

enzyme

cleaner. Nothing ammonia-based — it smells like the reason they went there in the first place.

Mud

Let it dry completely. Brush it off. Then wash. Working it wet spreads it into the fibres.

Three rules that cover most of it

Work from the outside of the mark inwards, or you spread it. **Blot, never rub** — rubbing pushes it into the fibres and roughs them up. And test anything new on a hidden corner first, because the second stain is the one you made yourself.

OURS, THE ONES THAT KEEP HAPPENING

WHAT WE KEEP FOR IT, AND WHERE

TAKEN TO A PROFESSIONAL

Some things are worth not ...



A whole house in two days is why it does not happen at all. One room a month is twelve rooms a year, it fits in an afternoon, and it means every room gets properly done once — which is more than a spring clean has managed in most houses since the last time somebody moved.

Write the room in, date it when it is done

MONTH	ROOM	DONE	✓
January			☐
February			☐
March			☐
April			☐
May			☐
June			☐
July			☐
August			☐
September			☐
October			☐
November			☐
December			☐

Every time, in every room

- ☐ Clean the surfaces before you clean anything
- ☐ Top down — dust falls, so ceilings and shelves before floors
- ☐ Dry work before wet work, or you make mud
- ☐ One room finished beats four rooms started
- ☐ Bin bag and a box for elsewhere, both in your hand

THIS ROOM, THE BITS THAT ONLY GET DONE NOW

Bin, charity, elsewhere, mending

WHAT WE FOUND WE DO NOT NEED AT ALL

What it actually took.



TIMED, NOT GUESSED Then correct page 3

DATE	WHAT GOT DONE	MINS

The job you keep putting off is usually not the job

It is a missing bin, a shelf that is too high, a cupboard you have to empty to get into, or a decision nobody has made. Write down **why** beside it rather than just writing it down again — half of them turn out to be a five-pound fix rather than a failure of character.

KEEPS GETTING PUT OFF — AND WHY

THE JOB	THE ACTUAL REASON

WORTH PAYING SOMEBODY FOR Hours, times what yo...

WHAT WE CHANGED, AND WHETHER IT HELD

Do this for a fortnight and the numbers on page 3 stop being guesses. Almost everybody is wrong in the same direction: the small jobs take four minutes rather than fifteen, and the ones that are put off for months take eleven.